

BRANSON POLITICAL REVIEW

DEMOCRATIC DISSONANCE

How partisan discourse can sustain
and complicate American Democracy

A collection of academic articles by
Branson students



A NOTE FROM THE EDITOR

Hello, and welcome to the third edition of the Branson Political Review. It is with great pride that I bring you the work of these incredibly dedicated and talented student writers and researchers.

In our current political climate, partisan discourse often gets a bad rap — disagreement is scapegoated as the culprit of division and inefficiency, cited as evidence of a decaying democracy. However, it is necessary to keep in mind that disagreement itself is not the problem. While discourse is the foundation of American Democracy, the way in which we disagree dictates the health of our political system. Thus, we must engage in responsible and civil discourse to sustain our governmental system.

A special thank you to Dr. Talia Di Manno for serving as our faculty advisor, and Christopher Mao for developing the website. This is my final edition as editor-in-chief and I look forward to passing the torch to Ashley Wang, Grant Kruttschnitt and Hazel Levinson.

Reese Furhman

TABLE OF CONTENTS

- [Trump and Tik Tok](#) by Max Chan
- [Algorithmic Polarization: Is Social Media Undermining Policy Debate?](#) by Ashley Wang
- [The Right to Protest](#) by Hazel Levinson
- [Sortion: Democracy Smaller But Better](#) by Grant Kruttschnitt

SPRING 2025 EDITION

TRUMP AND TIKTOK

By Max Chan

After extending the TikTok ban on April 5th, Trump is now struggling to make a deal with ByteDance's operations in the U.S. In 2020, Trump supported a ban, yet now he rejects it. Why the whiplash, and how did we get here?

A quick background: TikTok was started in 2014, with the release of Musical.ly, a short-form video sharing platform with a focus on lip-syncing and other music-related content. Headquartered in Shanghai, Musical.ly quickly gained popularity, garnering 200 million users worldwide, before being acquired by the Chinese company, ByteDance, in November 2017. The price tag was estimated to be between 800 million to 1 billion in U.S. dollars. ByteDance subsequently merged its users into TikTok in 2018. Powered by an addictive algorithm and the COVID-19 lockdown, TikTok quickly grew at a massive scale, and by 2021, it announced it had reached a billion users worldwide. In April 2022, they surpassed Instagram to become the most downloaded app in the world.



Canva

WHY IS TIKTOK BAD?

Since its introduction in the U.S, TikTok has always been considered a national security concern, particularly because of its relationship to China. The Washington Post noted it contained less sensitive Chinese political content like Tiananmen Square, Taiwan, and Hong Kong than other social media sites, suggesting that the Chinese Communist Party had some kind of control over what was shown on the app. In 2019, the U.S. government began an investigation into TikTok and its connection to the Chinese government and ordered all federal employees to delete the app from their devices. Concerns have also been raised about China stealing U.S. data, and whether the TikTok algorithm can be tampered with to spread Chinese propaganda, sway public opinion, or even influence elections abroad.

TWO-FACED TIKTOK TRUMP

Donald Trump, who had always been a strong advocate for a tough-on-China policy, said in 2020 that he would consider banning TikTok as punishment for China for their mishandling of the pandemic. Later in the year, he issued an executive order that ordered TikTok to sell its operations in the U.S. in 90 days or be banned. The order, dubbed "ban or sell," drew large controversy until the election of President Biden, who decided not to enforce the order.

But the TikTok ban resurfaced again in 2024, when a new bill gained steam in Congress with heavy bipartisan support. Both houses passed the bill with overwhelming majorities — the House by 360-58, and the Senate by 79-18.

Then, President-elect Trump implored the Supreme Court to block the bill, but the Court upheld it and set January 19th, 2025, for the ban to take effect. On January 18th, TikTok “went dark”, before coming back a day later after Trump affirmed it would find a different solution to the ban. After his inauguration, Trump signed an executive order extending the date of the TikTok ban, saying,

“TikTok is largely about kids, young kids. If China is gonna get information about young kids, I don’t know... I think we have bigger problems than that.”

Seeming to reverse his previous decision about TikTok's risk to national security, Trump now downplayed any data breach threat. So what caused this change in opinion? In the 2024 election, Trump himself made an account on the platform, using it as an outlet for his campaign to reach youth voters. This came with the newfound success of conservative content creators on TikTok, such as Joe Rogan and Charlie Kirk, who have become viral gurus spreading their beliefs on the app. Trump himself said in a press conference

“I have a warm spot in my heart for TikTok because I won youth by 34 points... and... there are those who say TikTok has something to do with it. ”

Afterwards, he explained that “those” people were his son, Barron Trump, and Joe Rogan. In actuality, Trump didn’t win the youth vote at all.

Regardless, Trump is right: TikTok does seem to favor him. A New York Post article published October 29th, 2024, noted that while both Harris and Trump started TikTok accounts for their campaigns in the summer, Trump had gained 12.5 million followers, while Harris had only half that at 6.2 million. Despite the longstanding bipartisan support to ban TikTok, Trump seemed to dramatically reverse course, no doubt, after seeing how the app could favor his party and benefit his own interests.



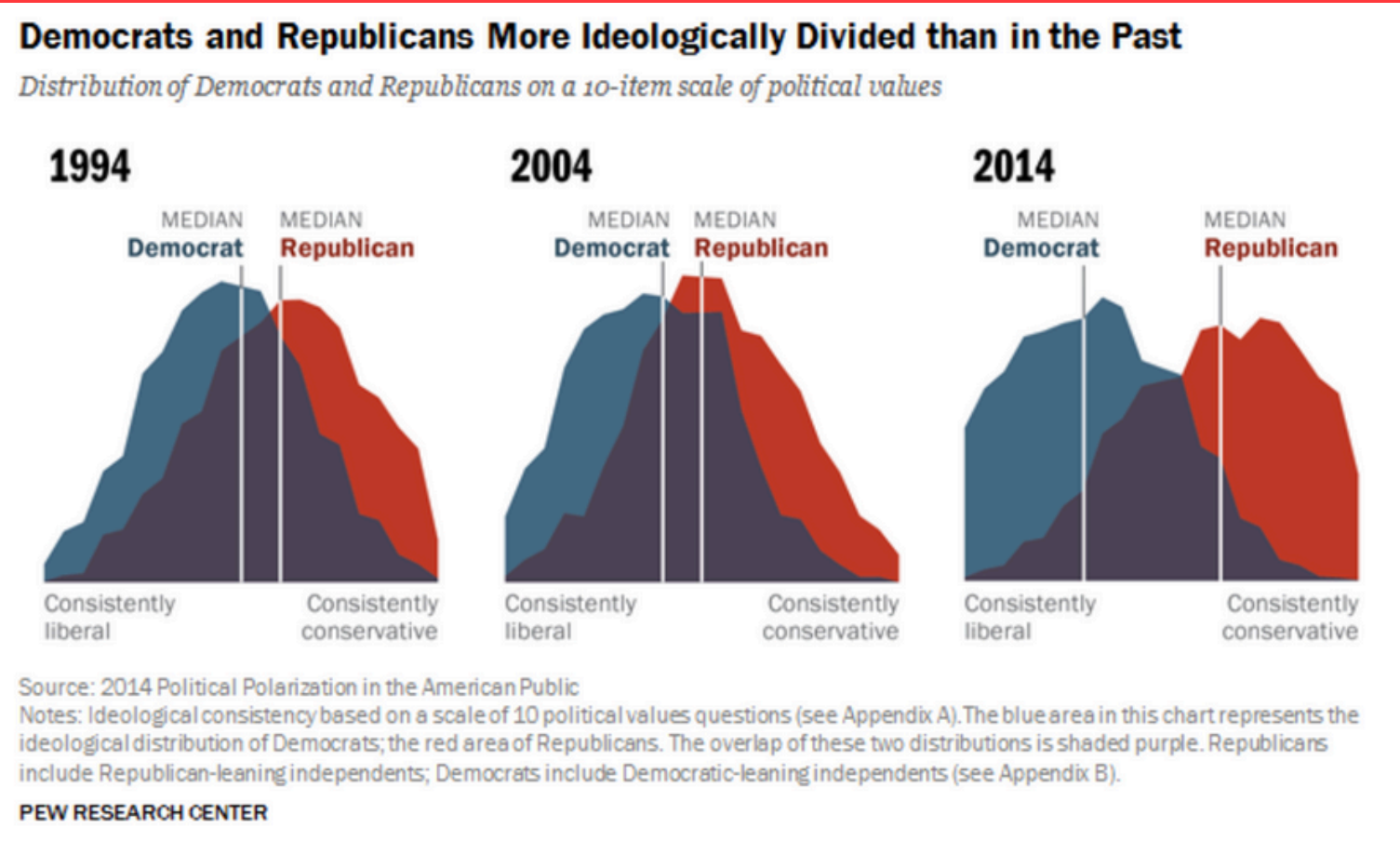
CNN

WHAT NOW?

After extending the ban to 75 days after his inauguration, Trump announced that he would postpone it another 75 days to try and work out a deal. He had proposed deals with potential buyers like Jeff Bezos and Elon Musk, both of whom have become some of Trump's biggest allies. Of course, even further, Trump's current trade war with China is jeopardizing the deal for the platform. TikTok has stated that they have 170 million U.S. users, around half of the population here, so many people do agree with Trump and oppose the ban. While Trump fights back against lawmakers, we still don't know what will happen at this time of writing.

ALGORITHMIC POLARIZATION: IS SOCIAL MEDIA UNDERMINING POLICY DEBATE?

By Ashley Wang



Pew Research

In the past two decades, American democracy has seen an increasing partisan divide. Political theorist, [Jennifer McCoy](#), defines polarization as “a process whereby the normal multiplicity of differences in a society increasingly align along a single dimension and people increasingly perceive and describe politics and society in terms of ‘Us’ versus ‘Them.’” This coincides with the direction of American democracy today.

According to a [Pew Research Center 2014 survey](#), the overall share of Americans who identify as consistently conservative or consistently liberal has doubled since 1994 from 10 percent to 21 percent. As a result, the ideological overlap has decreased significantly. Today, 92 percent of Republicans are to the right of the median Democrat, and 94 percent of Democrats are to the left of the median Republican. So, what has changed? Only the most transformative invention of 21st century life—social media.

The [first true social media platform, Six Degrees](#), launched in 1997. It was the first to have the characteristics that we are so familiar with on modern social media sites. Users could create profiles, maintain lists of friends, and contact one another through internal messaging systems. The evolution continued into the 21st century. In 2006, Twitter introduced the idea of “microblogging” and “real-time updates,” with the short character count and hashtag phenomenon. By 2010, Instagram created the feature that many associate with social media today—photo and video sharing. Today, around [239 million Americans](#) are active users on social media sites.

So why does this matter? More importantly, what does it have to do with politics? Social media has transformed the way that Americans consume media and information. This not only includes information about family and friends, but also the world around them. Today, many Americans go-to political news source is not the New York Times or CNN, but rather the “news influencers” that they see on Instagram and Tiktok.

This creates two key consequences. First, the drive of misinformation. Misinformation got six times more clicks and interactions on Facebook than factual news [during the 2020 election](#). This becomes increasingly worrisome when we take into account that Facebook has the means to shape an election in the United States with its [2.9 billion users](#).

Misinformation isn't just false headlines. It can be emotionally charged and extremely divisive content that is weaponized through social media.

It is extremely easy to create false advertisements with the power to sway a crucial majority. For example, a post commonly found on right-wing Facebook groups shows a collage of old and unlabeled photos of wounded police officers claiming that it was the result of [violent caravan migrants](#). These drastic images with this caption could be easily believed with the large numbers of Americans who receive their news primarily from social media. This post has the potential to sway a large group of voters who are concerned about immigrants and the threats that are illustrated to come with them. These types of extreme posts are the ones that need to be monitored and regulated the most.

Then, there are the inherent issues of social media that are unintentionally fueling political extremism. Social media platforms such as Instagram, Facebook, and TikTok use an algorithm to maximize consumer engagement and addiction. They value the quantity of content that you intake rather than the quality. Their business model uses your scrolling patterns to create algorithms that feed you content that you are most likely to engage with. This either comes in the form of relatable content or extreme attention grabbing content that will evoke large responses—either positive or negative.



The Claw

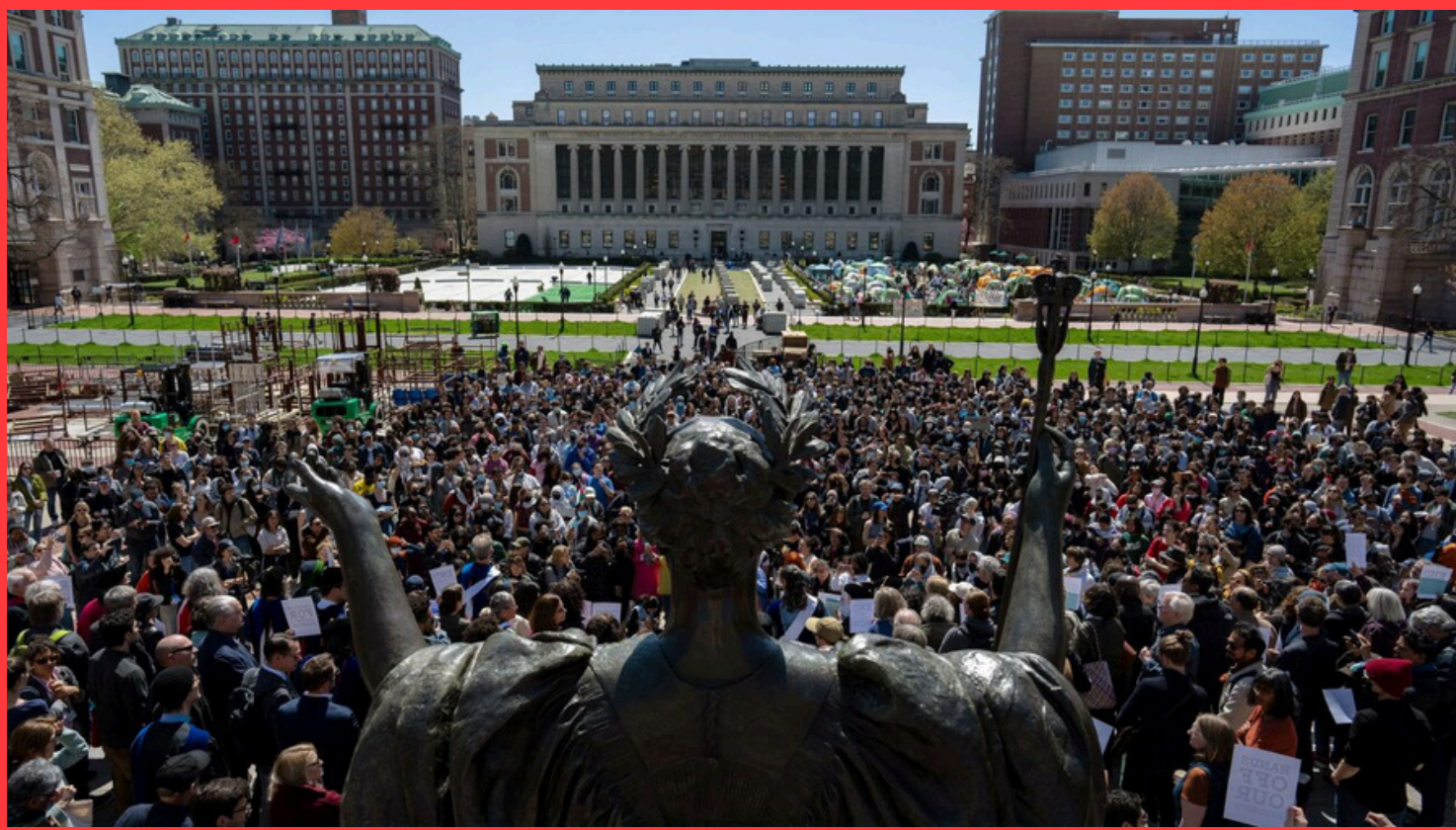
Ultimately, what is created is an echo chamber, where individuals rarely interact with those with opposing political views, and if they ever do, it is in a negative manner. What is destroyed, however, is political discourse, reaching across the aisle, and compromise. These are the key tenets of a thriving democracy.

So if all of the above is true and nearly 75 percent of our country actively engages in social media, then how can we try to prevent the impacts of democratic dissonance? It is extremely important for schools and community institutions to create space for civil discourse. As we navigate the world we live in today, where political opinions have been weaponized, it becomes increasingly difficult to separate fact from rhetoric, making it all the more important to cultivate critical thinking and empathy in our political discussions.

THE RIGHT TO PROTEST

By Hazel Levinson

The right to protest is a cornerstone of democratic societies, allowing citizens to express dissent and call for change. However, as protests regarding issues like the Israel-Palestine conflict, it's essential to consider where the line between free speech and hate speech is drawn. Protests, while a vital expression of democracy, can easily devolve into platforms for hate, which raises critical questions about policy, accountability, and the role of protest organizers. When does free speech cross into hate speech? And when does that hate speech become discrimination? Where, exactly, should we draw the line?



ABC News

The Universal Declaration for Human Rights (UDHR) enshrines the right to peaceful protest in Article 20, emphasizing its importance for individual freedom and democratic engagement. Protests have been instrumental in social change, such as the Civil Rights Movement and anti-apartheid protests internationally. They allow individuals to challenge policies, raise awareness, and push for reforms.

While protests are an essential democratic tool, they are not without limits. Many legal systems recognize the potential harm in allowing hate speech, which can incite violence and discrimination.

Protests can veer into hate speech when political criticism turns into attacks on entire communities. For instance, some pro-Palestinian rallies have included expressions of anti-Semitism. At Columbia University, one of the nation's most prestigious institutions, student groups have staged encampments on the South Lawn and in various libraries and halls of the school. Jewish students on campus have faced chants such as "we don't want no Zionists here," "death to the Zionist state," and "go back to Poland," fostering an environment where a minority is under fire.

Zionism is defined as "a movement for (originally) the re-establishment and (now) the development and protection of a Jewish nation in what is now Israel" but has ties to the Torah and the book of Genesis. While not intrinsically tied to Judaism, a strong minority of Jewish people identify as Zionists. As the media attempts to portray Zionism as an eradication of a Palestinian state, Zionism truly and factually represents only the belief that Jewish people have a right to their ancestral homeland.

Another Columbia protest organization is Within our Lifetime firmly rejects "all collaboration and dialogue with zionist organizations through a strict policy of anti-normalization." So, we are called to ask: how can change occur when one does not know the side they are fighting against. It is easy to hate zionists if you believe they are all anti-Palestinian but when instead people seek genuine information and talk to those who disagree or hold different ideologies, real change can occur.

Of course, the same should be true for Jewish students on college campuses engaging in counter protests. Many protesters are influenced by the media to take firm stances on either side of the issue but without negotiation and explanations from all involved in protests and discourse, change will not be made.

SORTION: DEMOCRACY SMALLER BUT BETTER

By Grant Kruttschnitt

"[I]t is on great occasions only, and after time has been given for cool and deliberate reflection, that the real voice of the people can be known."

George Washington

Right now, only about 60% of Americans know what parties are in control of the Senate and House of Representatives. Less than half know the three branches of the American government (UPenn).

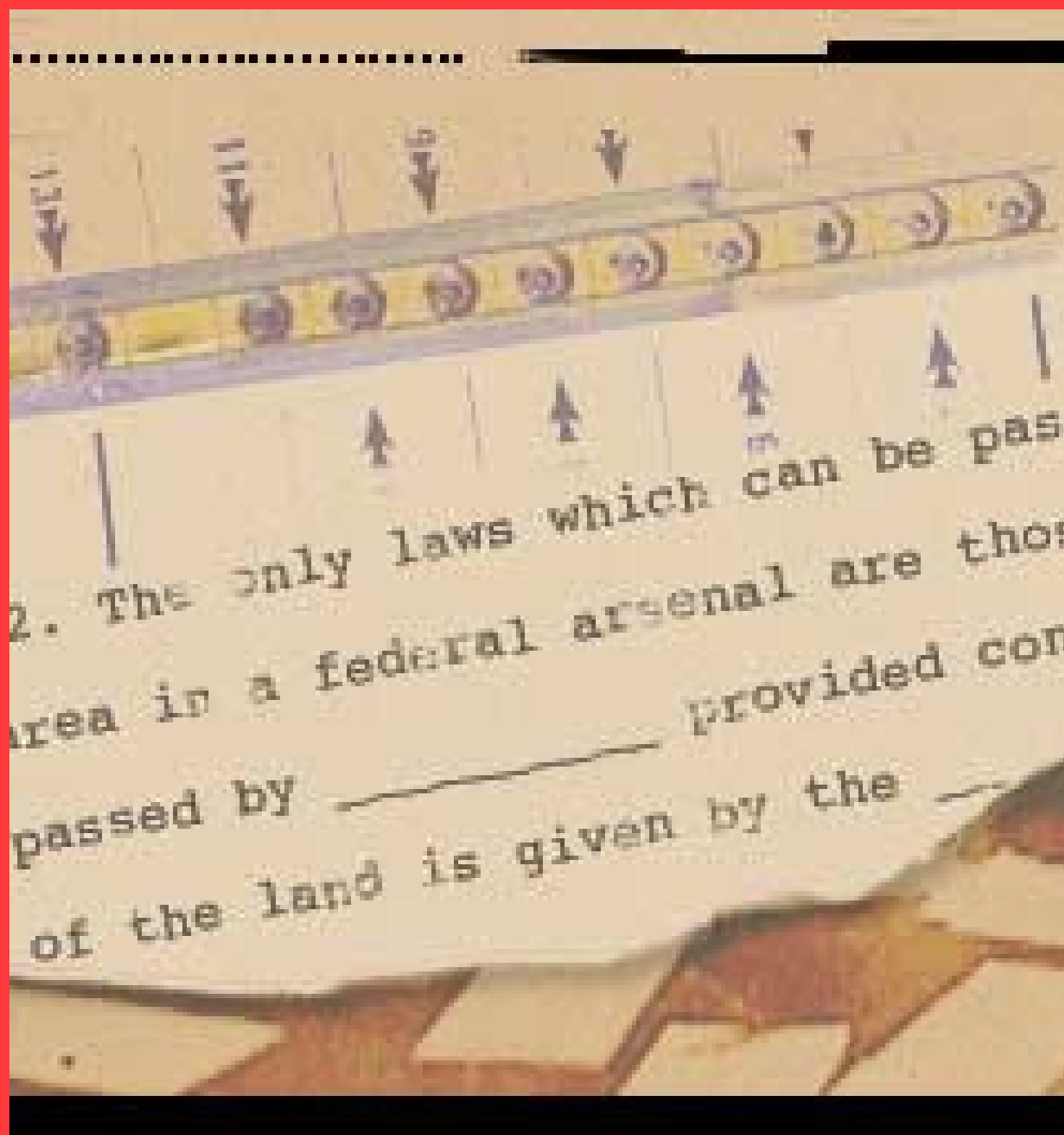


The New Yorker

It is hard to imagine that voters are making informed ballots without these basic political facts. When things get more complicated, such as in different candidates' economic policies, how are voters supposed to compare when they don't even know that there exists a tradeoff between inflation and unemployment (NBER)? While voter ignorance sounds like a simple problem, the solution is difficult to achieve.

One way to make voters more informed is by educating them. We already educate almost everyone for twelve years already, but we could try to expand this by making schools better and college cheaper. However, while those things would have benefits, political knowledge would still likely remain low. Even with twelve years of school, one in three Americans still don't know the branches of government. Slight changes in this arena would likely not have an impact great enough to create a fully informed populace.

Another way to make voters more informed is to set an informational bar with a test. A test could evaluate basic political concepts and economic ideas, and accuracy could determine the proportional impact of your vote. However, there would likely be bias while designing this test, as was the case with the racially discriminatory voting tests during the Jim Crow Era. Even if it did not reach that blatantly racist level, it would be impossible to create a completely neutral test. The only way a test like this could be fair would be if the questions were straightforward and simple — all possible questions could be put online so individuals could learn about specific topics before voting. However, this would favor those who had extra time to learn these things, and it would be morally questionable, because those who failed the test would not get any representation in government.



PBS

At first glance, those seem like the only ways to improve the information of voters. What else could you change, besides educating the general population more or making sure only knowledgeable people can vote? The third way would be to prepare the voter population specifically. What I am proposing is sortition, the selection of random people, to serve as a presidential jury that would then be educated for the task of voting. Here's how it would work:

1. People would run normal campaigns in a general election and then voting would occur. The top five candidates would then move on to the next round.
2. Each state would randomly select hundreds of registered voters to represent the state's population as a whole.
3. Over the course of four weeks, advocates from the politicians from the first election will make their case to these selected voters who would spend all of their time on deciding this task. Different experts would come in and give an overview of the policies proposed by each candidate. The voters will discuss these different policies among themselves which would get them to see each other's view, making it more likely that they will support moderates.
4. Then, the voters will vote on who they think the president should be, and the one receiving the most votes would win.

B

This idea goes back to the days of Ancient Athens, where councils and courts were filled by randomly selected candidates. This random selection was the first definition of 'democracy', and it was only relatively recently with the American and French revolutions that 'democracy' mainly came to mean 'electoral democracy' ([The Collector](#)). We still do follow some of these principles today — in court cases, we just select a random 9 person sample as a representative jury so they can learn about the case and make a decision. We would consider it folly if the whole population would vote on a court case without knowing the details — why should elections be any different?



Share America

This system would actually allow voters to make the best choice possible in terms of substance, instead of things like campaign messaging deciding the winner of the election. Right now, only about 28% of Americans are satisfied with the way democracy is working ([Gallup](#)). Part of that low satisfaction is how effective policy isn't able to help that much in campaigning, because a lot of information is needed to know what is effective policy and what is not, which means it often isn't implemented.

Almost no one has time to go through the hundreds of pages of policy proposals that politicians publish — most people only get a review of it second-hand, if they hear about it at all. It's political theatre, where politicians publish detailed policy proposals because they are expected, not because they will actually change voters' opinions. These proposals being theatre even leads to the breakdown of the whole mechanism and point of democracy — government is supposed to respond to what voters want. However, that doesn't happen in American democracy at the moment, because voters aren't informed enough to know what candidate is offering what they want. In sortition, though, the representative group of Americans that become highly informed voters will be able to dive into the depths of each candidate's policies. They'll signal to the government about what the people truly want.

A common argument against this is that it wouldn't work because people are too stuck in their political beliefs that a few weeks of information would not convince them. However, studies have shown that discussion does convince people to change minds. In an American study where they got hundreds of people to discuss different policy ideas, both Republicans and Democrats moved to the center on positions, with support of various policies changing by up to forty percent ([NYTimes](#)). It would indeed get more complicated where these beliefs are attached to a candidate instead of specific policies, and at first, voters might not be as open to changing their minds.

But as political polarization decreases, and as this system becomes more familiar, it would become more accepted to think of the first election as merely a trial run, and for the selected voters to go into the sortition discussions with their mind completely open.

In conclusion, I truly think that this would improve our political system so much. I don't really think that this, or anything like this will be implemented close to soon. However, our current political system would have also been a pipe dream for people thousands of years ago, and I think it's important to think about radically better policies, in addition to incremental change.